

# MADE IN THE USA



A PLATE FOR EVERY STATE



*50 States · 56 Recipes · One American Table*

CHRISTINA REED

## **Made in the USA: A Plate for Every State**

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# WELCOME TO OUR PLACE



Let us take you on a culinary adventure throughout the United States. Food is how we remember where we've been and who we were when we were there.

It's the sandwich wrapped in wax paper on a long drive, the pie that only shows up at holidays, the recipe that tastes different depending on whose kitchen you're standing in. Long before we remember street names or mile markers, we remember meals. And in America, those meals change every time you cross a state line.

Made in the USA: A Plate for Every State is a celebration of that idea — that every place has a flavor, and every flavor has a story. From coast to coast, this book travels through all 50 states, sharing the dishes that locals grow up with, argue about, and proudly claim as their own.

Some of these recipes are famous. Others are quiet classics. Some were born out of necessity, others out of celebration. All of them belong to the places they come from. Paired with each recipe is a story rooted in geography, history, memory, or tradition, because food doesn't exist in a vacuum. It exists at tables, in families, and in moments worth remembering.

This isn't a rule-heavy cookbook or a quest for perfection. It's meant to be cooked from, laughed over, and occasionally splattered with sauce. Measurements are familiar, instructions are approachable, and the focus is always on flavor and feeling, not fuss.

Whether you're recreating something that feels like home, discovering a new regional favorite, or simply curious about how the country eats, this book invites you to slow down and take a seat.

After all, the best way to understand a place has always been the same.

*Pull up a chair.*

*Pass the plate.*

*Stay awhile.*

## NOTES FROM THE KITCHEN

# TEMPERATURES & DONENESS



*Every oven, grill, and pot of oil in this book carries both Fahrenheit and Celsius — so the recipes travel as easily as the dishes themselves.*

When a cut of meat needs a particular internal temperature, an instant-read thermometer is the surest path; color and time will only take you so far. The marks these recipes lean on most are gathered here.

| What you're cooking           | Aim for                            |
|-------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| Deep- or shallow-frying       | 350–375°F (175–190°C)              |
| Beef, medium-rare             | 130°F (54°C)                       |
| Beef, medium                  | 140–145°F (60–63°C)                |
| Ground meats & burgers        | 160°F (71°C)                       |
| Poultry, cooked through       | 165°F (74°C)                       |
| Fish, flaky and just done     | 145°F (63°C)                       |
| A low, slow roast (prime rib) | 200°F (93°C) oven, then seared hot |
| Most baking in this book      | 350–400°F (175–204°C)              |

Doneness is a matter of taste as much as safety — pull meat a few degrees early and let it rest, and it will climb to just where you want it.

*Now — To the hearth. Let's begin.*



# ALABAMA



*The Yellowhammer State*



In the Tennessee Valley of northern Alabama, where the river bends west through Decatur and the land flattens toward the Mississippi border, a railroad man named Bob Gibson spent his weekends tending a fire. It was 1925. Gibson worked the line for the L&N Railroad, but on Saturdays and Sundays he dug a pit in his own backyard, laid hickory coals in the bottom, and smoked chicken and pork for anyone who wandered by. He nailed oak planks to a big sycamore tree to make a serving table, and the smoke that rose off that pit pulled neighbors and fellow railway workers down the road from miles around. Standing six feet four and weighing better than three hundred pounds, he was Big Bob to everyone who knew him, a man his family still describes as never having met a stranger.

What set Gibson apart wasn't only the smoke. It was what he did with his chickens once they came off the pit. Across the rest of the South, barbecue meant a tomato sauce, or a thin vinegar mop like the ones traded down from the Carolinas. Gibson went another direction entirely. He whisked together mayonnaise, vinegar, and a heavy hand of black pepper into a pale, tangy sauce, and he dunked his whole smoked chickens straight into it before serving. The mayonnaise clung to the hickory-smoked skin where a watery sauce would have run off; the vinegar and pepper cut the richness of the bird and kept the meat from drying out over the long, dry heat of the pit. It was cooling where barbecue was hot, sharp where it was smoky, and unlike anything else on a Southern table. Word traveled the way good food always does in a small city, and before long the crowds in Gibson's backyard outgrew the sycamore tree. He left the railroad, opened a restaurant, and Big Bob Gibson Bar-B-Q became a Decatur institution that his family still runs today, a full century after that first backyard fire.

For decades the sauce stayed close to home. This was northern Alabama's own secret, a Tennessee Valley specialty you found at Decatur pits, church suppers, and county cookouts but rarely anywhere past the state's midline. Cooks up and down the valley made their own versions, arguing over how much vinegar, whether to add a little lemon or horseradish, how much pepper was too much. It wasn't until the sauce was first bottled and sold commercially in the 1990s that the rest of the country caught on, and Alabama white sauce began turning up on menus far from the river that raised it. Today it's recognized as Alabama's signature contribution to American barbecue, but its heart never left the northern part of the state.

The dish that carries the sauce best is the simplest one: smoked or grilled chicken, cooled and brightened by that peppery white dressing, tucked into something soft to catch the drips. Big Bob served whole birds, but the same magic happens on a smaller scale, on a slider bun, at a backyard table where the first one off the tray never quite makes it onto a plate. Cool and tangy against char and smoke, it's northern Alabama's gift to the cookout, and it rewards you the moment the chicken hits the heat and the sauce comes together in the bowl.

# Grilled Chicken Sliders with Alabama White Sauce

*Big Bob Gibson's tangy white sauce turned smoked chicken into a northern Alabama secret worth guarding for decades.*



Yield: 6 sliders

## INGREDIENTS

- ★ 2 boneless, skinless chicken breasts
  - ★ 1 tsp garlic powder
  - ★ 1 tsp smoked paprika
  - ★ Salt and pepper, to taste
  - ★ 1 Tbsp olive oil
  - ★ 6 slider buns
  - ★ 1 cup Alabama White Sauce\*
  - ★ ½ cup coleslaw (optional)
  - ★ Sliced pickles (optional)
- \*See Alabama White Sauce, below.

## INSTRUCTIONS

1. Prep the chicken: Pound the chicken breasts to even thickness and cut into smaller pieces if needed. Season with garlic powder, smoked paprika, salt, and pepper.
2. Cook the chicken: Heat olive oil in a skillet or grill pan over medium-high heat and cook the chicken for 4–5 minutes per side, until fully cooked through.
3. Assemble and serve: Toss the cooked chicken in Alabama White Sauce and place on slider buns. Top with coleslaw and pickles if desired, and serve immediately.

## Alabama White Sauce



Yield: 1 cup

## INGREDIENTS

- ★ 1 cup mayonnaise
- ★ ¼ cup apple cider vinegar
- ★ 1 Tbsp lemon juice
- ★ 2 tsp sugar
- ★ 1 tsp prepared horseradish
- ★ 1 tsp salt
- ★ 1 tsp pepper
- ★ ¼ tsp cayenne pepper (optional, to taste)

## INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix: In a bowl, whisk together all ingredients until smooth and well combined.
2. Adjust and chill: Taste and adjust seasoning, adding more horseradish or cayenne if you like extra kick. Cover and refrigerate for at least 30 minutes to let the flavors meld (though it's delicious right away too).



PROVISIONAL CROP — final hi-res image to come



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- ★ Sliced pickles (optional)

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## INSTRUCTIONS

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# GRILLED CHICKEN SLIDERS WITH ALABAMA WHITE SAUCE

*Big Bob Gibson's tangy white sauce turned smoked chicken into a northern Alabama secret worth guarding for decades.*



Yield: 6 sliders

## INGREDIENTS

- |                                        |                                  |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| ★ 2 boneless, skinless chicken breasts | ★ 6 slider buns                  |
| ★ 1 tsp garlic powder                  | ★ 1 cup Alabama White Sauce*     |
| ★ 1 tsp smoked paprika                 | ★ ½ cup coleslaw (optional)      |
| ★ Salt and pepper, to taste            | ★ Sliced pickles (optional)      |
| ★ 1 Tbsp olive oil                     | *See Alabama White Sauce, below. |

## INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prep the chicken:* Pound the chicken breasts to even thickness and cut into smaller pieces if needed. Season with garlic powder, smoked paprika, salt, and pepper.
2. *Cook the chicken:* Heat olive oil in a skillet or grill pan over medium-high heat and cook the chicken for 4–5 minutes per side, until fully cooked through.
3. *Assemble and serve:* Toss the cooked chicken in Alabama White Sauce and place on slider buns. Top with coleslaw and pickles if desired, and serve immediately.

## ALABAMA WHITE SAUCE



Yield: 1 cup

## INGREDIENTS

- |                             |                                             |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| ★ 1 cup mayonnaise          | ★ 1 tsp prepared horseradish                |
| ★ ¼ cup apple cider vinegar | ★ 1 tsp salt                                |
| ★ 1 Tbsp lemon juice        | ★ 1 tsp pepper                              |
| ★ 2 tsp sugar               | ★ ¼ tsp cayenne pepper (optional, to taste) |

## INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Mix:* In a bowl, whisk together all ingredients until smooth and well combined.
2. *Adjust and chill:* Taste and adjust seasoning, adding more horseradish or cayenne if you like extra kick. Cover and refrigerate for at least 30 minutes to let the flavors meld (though it's delicious right away too).

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